Judges and Ruth

Judges 2; 6–8; 21; Ruth 1–4

The big idea: Within one generation Israel forgot God and spiraled down, and everyone did what was right in his own eyes. In the same dark years God quietly brought a Moabite widow under his wings through a kinsman-redeemer, Boaz, and from them came David, and finally Jesus, our Redeemer and King.

Before you meet: Read

Judges 2:6–23 | Judges 7:1–22 | Judges 21:25 | Ruth 1–4

Open (5 minutes)

Who passed faith on to you, or who do you wish had? What made the difference?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"And there arose another _____ after them who did not know the LORD or the work that he had done for Israel." *(Judges 2:10)*

"For the LORD was moved to _____ by their groaning because of those who afflicted and oppressed them." *(Judges 2:18)*

"I will not rule over you, and my son will not rule over you; the _____ will rule over you." *(Judges 8:23)*

"In those days there was no _____ in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own _____." *(Judges 21:25)*

"And she _____ to come to the part of the field belonging to Boaz." *(Ruth 2:3)*

"Spread your wings over your servant, for you are a _____." *(Ruth 3:9)*

Discuss

1. Judges 2:10 describes a generation that did not know the LORD. How can faith be lost in a single generation? What guards against it? *Judges 2:10; Deuteronomy 6:7*

2. Where do you see the cycle of Judges in your own life: sin, trouble, crying out, rescue, and back again? *Judges 2:11–19*

3. God cut Gideon's army to 300 so that Israel could not boast. Why does God so often choose weakness to show his strength? *Judges 7:2*

4. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes. Where do you see that in our culture? Where do you see it in yourself? *Judges 21:25*

5. Naomi said the LORD had brought her back empty. Was she right? How does the rest of the story answer her? *Ruth 1:20–21; 4:14–17*

6. A redeemer had to be a close relative, able to pay, and willing to pay. How does Jesus fulfill each one?
Hebrews 2:14; 1 Peter 1:18–19; Galatians 4:4–5

Apply this week

Read the book of Ruth in one sitting this week; it takes about twenty minutes. Then tell one younger person, a child, grandchild, or newer believer, one specific thing God has done for you, so that the next generation knows the LORD and his works.

Memory verse

"For where you go I will go, and where you lodge I will lodge. Your people shall be my people, and your God my God."

Ruth 1:16

Pray

Confess the places where you do what is right in your own eyes. Thank God for his quiet providence in your story. Thank Jesus, your Redeemer, who became your brother and paid your price, and ask him to rule your heart as King.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 13

Judges and Ruth

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Judges 2:6–19 aloud together. Then read Ruth 1:15–18 and 4:13–17.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 5, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Downward Spiral diagram and the family line from Judah to Jesus in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 14 (1 Samuel 8, 16, and 17; 2 Samuel 7).

Main points to land

1. Faith can be lost in one generation. Judges begins with children who did not know the LORD (Judges 2:10), the opposite of Deuteronomy 6:7.
2. Judges is a downward spiral of sin, trouble, groaning, and rescue. God disciplined Israel and, moved by compassion, rescued them again and again (Judges 2:11–19).
3. The judges were flawed rescuers. They saved for a while but could not change hearts. Israel needed a king who would do right in God's eyes (Judges 21:25).
4. Ruth shows God's quiet providence and his welcome of outsiders. A Moabite widow takes refuge under the wings of Israel's God and becomes David's great-grandmother (Ruth 2:12; 4:17).
5. Boaz the kinsman-redeemer points to Jesus, who became our relative, paid with his own blood, and was willing to give everything (Hebrews 2:14; 1 Peter 1:18–19).

Core doctrine to teach

Election and Sovereign Grace

CORE DOCTRINE 13 OF 26 · GRACE ALONE

Salvation begins with God, not with us. Before the world began God chose a people to save, not because of anything good in them, but out of his own love. He calls outsiders like Ruth, a Moabite widow, into his family. Grace is undeserved, and it is the only reason anyone is saved. *Ruth 1:16; 2:10; Ephesians 1:4–5; 2:8–9; John 6:37*

Answer key (Observe)

1. generation
2. pity
3. LORD
4. king; eyes
5. happened

6. redeemer

Questions people will ask

If Gideon and Samson did such terrible things, why does Hebrews 11 list them as heroes of faith?
Hebrews honors their faith, not their whole lives. God works through weak and sinful people who trust him, even a little, and Samson's last act was a cry to the LORD (Judges 16:28). Their failures show why Israel needed a better rescuer, and why we do too.

Deuteronomy 23:3 says no Moabite may enter the assembly. How could Ruth be accepted?
The law shut out Moab as a nation that met Israel with curses (Deuteronomy 23:4). Ruth came the other way, leaving her gods and taking refuge under the LORD. The prophets promised that foreigners who hold fast to God would be welcomed (Isaiah 56:3–7). Ruth is an early sign that faith, not birth, brings people into God's family.

What was happening at the threshing floor in Ruth 3? It sounds strange.
Ruth was making a marriage proposal in the customs of her day. Asking Boaz to spread the corner of his cloak over her meant asking him to marry and protect her (Ezekiel 16:8). Boaz calls her a worthy woman and protects her honor, sending her home before dawn (Ruth 3:11, 14). The scene is about integrity and courage.

Was Deborah a judge over men? What does that mean for church leadership?
Deborah was a prophetess who settled disputes, and God spoke through her to call Barak to lead the army (Judges 4:4–9). Faithful Christians draw different lessons from her story, and Reformed churches read it alongside the New Testament's teaching on church offices. Keep the group on the main point: God raised up rescuers when his people cried out.

Closing prayer

Father, you did not abandon your people in their darkest days, and you quietly wrote a story of redemption through a Moabite widow and a kind farmer. Keep us from doing what is right in our own eyes. Help us pass on your works to the next generation. Thank you for Jesus, our Redeemer and King, who became our brother and paid our price. Shelter us under your wings. Amen.